

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, September 12, 2026

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RE: Fiji's Employment Minister dies in Brisbane · Solomon Islands opposition alleges Australian treaty leak · Rudd puts Taiwan invasion odds at one-in-three by 2028 · Hastie says Hanson's Coalition grip broken · Peters committed NZ to host PIF without Cabinet sign-off

ASX 200

8,741

-2.94%

AUD/USD

0.7173

-0.46%

NZX 50

13,580

-2.82%

NZD/USD

0.5816

-1.14%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's Cabinet lost Employment Minister Agni Deo Singh, who died in Brisbane, opening a National Federation Party list seat that Labasa bus operator Parmod Chand is positioned to fill.
- 2 Solomon Islands opposition MPs accused Australia of interfering in domestic politics after a text message detailing bilateral treaty negotiations leaked, ABC's Pacific Review reported.
- 3 New Zealand Treasury advice shows Foreign Minister Winston Peters committed to hosting a Pacific Islands Forum leaders meeting without Cabinet approval, 1News reported.

• TOP STORIES

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Rudd puts odds of Chinese invasion of Taiwan by 2028 at one in three

Former prime minister **Kevin Rudd** told ABC's *Insiders on Background* there is a *one-in-three chance* China could invade Taiwan in 2028. Rudd, who also served as ambassador to the United States, set out the global risks of an attack on Taiwan and what a conflict would mean for Australia. He paired that assessment with a warning about artificial intelligence as a national security threat, in an interview with David Speers.

per ABC (*Insiders on Background*): "What are the risks Australia faces if China attacks Taiwan? - ABC listen"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji's Employment Minister Agni Deo Singh dies in Brisbane

Fiji's government announced the death of **Agni Deo Singh**, Minister for Employment, Productivity and Workplace Relations, in Brisbane. Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka**, who chairs the Coalition Cabinet, acknowledged Singh's dedicated service to Fiji's workers and his contribution to the nation. Singh served as general secretary of the Fiji Teachers Union from 1999 to 2006. The Office of the Prime Minister said funeral arrangements would be communicated in due course.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji government announces death of a Cabinet Minister" · also Fiji Sun

AU-POLITICS

Hastie says Hanson's hold on the Coalition has been broken

Liberal MP **Andrew Hastie** said **Pauline Hanson's** hold on the Coalition has been broken after a bruising feud that turned personal. The Australian Financial Review reported that Hastie's colleagues are mostly enthusiastic about his decision to take the fight to One Nation. The dispute follows the 'traitor' video row over Hastie's military service, carried in this brief on September 9 and 10.

per Sydney Morning Herald (Peter Hartcher): "Why Hastie v Hanson has become a defining moment for One Nation ... and the Coalition" · also AFR

• OVERNIGHT

AU-POLITICS

Pezzullo says Home Affairs deradicalisation needs a 'reset' · The Australian

Pezzullo told The Australian that Home Affairs' deradicalisation work requires a reset. The intervention follows reporting on September 11 that Labor's \$75 million anti-extremism programme is failing most participants.

AU-POLITICS

Optus apologises after outage disrupts emergency calls · Reuters

Optus apologised for a network outage that disrupted emergency calls, Reuters reported. ABC News said *41 triple zero calls* were affected across Victoria, with customers in Victoria, Tasmania and the Northern Territory hit. Victoria's Health Minister is demanding a thorough investigation into the telco's latest failure.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ABC tracks escalation in kinetic and economic warfare in Europe and the Gulf · ABC News

The ABC reports an escalation in both missile exchanges and sanctions this week, with new rounds against Israel, Iran and Cuba. The U.S. House of Representatives is scheduled to vote next week on sweeping tariffs on countries buying Russian oil and gas, though it is unclear whether the vote will proceed. Iran-backed Houthis now control Mocha, *50 kilometres* from the Bab el-Mandeb Strait.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Saudi Arabia shuts key oil pipeline after repeated attacks · The Australian

Saudi Arabia has closed a crucial oil pipeline following repeated attacks, The Australian reports. The shutdown removes one of Riyadh's workarounds for the Strait of Hormuz blockade. Brent stood at *104.61*, up 6.83 percent as of September 11.

• STAT OF THE DAY

16,770

child abuse cases recorded in Fiji, 2012-2025

Fiji's Ministry of Women, Children and Social Protection released the figure as a new care home opened in Nadi, with 5,329 of the cases classified as neglect.

Fiji Sun

• PACIFIC WIRE

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Bus operator Parmod Chand set to enter Fiji parliament

Businessman and Assemblies of God pastor **Parmod Chand** is expected to take the National Federation Party seat vacated by Agni Deo Singh's death. Chand, a Labasa-based bus operator, polled *1,857 votes* and is the next eligible NFP member. The NFP won five seats in the 2022 elections.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Acting PM appeals for unity as Cabinet weighs constitutional review report

Acting Prime Minister **Manoa Kamikamica** said Cabinet has met virtually almost every day since last weekend to work through the Constitutional Review Commission's report. 'We desperately need a change of Constitution,' he said, calling for amendments that are 'more democratic, more fairer to all of us'. He appealed to Fijians of all religions to pray for the country.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ABC PACIFIC

Solomon Islands opposition accuses Australia of interference over leaked treaty text

Opposition MPs in Solomon Islands accused Australia of interfering in domestic politics after a text message detailing bilateral treaty negotiations was leaked, ABC's Pacific Review reported. The same programme noted Samoa has revived debate over whether citizens living overseas should vote in local elections, and that New Caledonia is still recovering from 2024 unrest that cost billions of dollars and crippled tourism.

VANUATU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Vanuatu meteorological service wins international aviation certification

The Civil Aviation Authority of Vanuatu presented Quality Management Certification to the Vanuatu Meteorology and Hydrological Services last week, closing a 14-year process. Vanuatu joins Fiji, Papua New Guinea, Solomon Islands, French Polynesia and New Caledonia with internationally accepted aviation meteorological certification. CAAV air navigation manager **Pelensly Lulu** said certification 'marks the beginning of an ongoing responsibility'.

REGIONAL · VANUATU DAILY POST

Pacific moves towards a unified meteorological strategy

The Pacific Islands Meteorological Strategy is being positioned as a stronger regional framework to improve meteorological services, strengthen coordination, and ensure weather and climate information better supports communities across the region.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

Santo and TORBA operators press government on Pekoa runway upgrade

Tourism operators from Santo and TORBA attending the fourth Mi Tumoro Vanuatu Travel Expo in Port Vila called on the government to prioritise upgrading Pekoa International Airport to develop Luganville. Runway capacity governs which aircraft can serve northern Vanuatu.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji records 16,770 child abuse cases over 14 years

Fiji recorded 16,770 cases of child abuse between 2012 and 2025, of which 5,329 were neglect, according to Ministry of Women, Children and Social Protection records. Minister **Sashi Kiran** released the figures at the opening of the Phos Haven Care Home at Meigunyah, Nadi, which cares for 12 children and young people, including five with disabilities.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Madang police step up small-craft safety enforcement after boat incidents

Madang police are enforcing small-craft safety laws more strictly after two separate boat incidents left three people missing in the province. Maritime safety enforcement across PNG's provincial waters remains thin relative to the volume of small-boat traffic.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · 1NEWS

Treasury says Peters committed to host Pacific Islands Forum without Cabinet approval

Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** committed New Zealand to hosting a Pacific Islands Forum leaders meeting without Cabinet approval, according to Treasury. The disclosure lands eight weeks out from the November 7 general election and days after the 55th Leaders Meeting in Koror passed the chair to Palau.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · AFR

AFR: Hastie's colleagues mostly enthusiastic about taking on One Nation

Liberal MP **Andrew Hastie** has decided to take the fight up to One Nation and his colleagues are mostly enthusiastic, the Australian Financial Review reports. The question for the party room is whether the confrontation turns **Pauline Hanson** from victim into villain among conservative voters.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Bowen calls Hanson's attack on the PM's late mother 'off limits'

Pauline Hanson turned personal on **Anthony Albanese's** late mother, drawing a rebuke from **Chris Bowen**, who said the subject was 'off limits', The Australian reports. The exchange runs alongside the Hastie feud consuming the Coalition's right flank.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

SMH: Labor's online rulebook is its most ambitious assault on Silicon Valley yet

Anthony Albanese and **Anika Wells** are mounting by far the most ambitious attempt yet to rewrite the domestic rulebook for the internet, the Sydney Morning Herald reports. The digital duty of care bill has already drawn a censorship charge from Opposition Leader **Angus Taylor**, carried in this brief on September 10.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Labor defends independence of space grants tied to Aboriginal knowledge

The government says space grants embedding Aboriginal knowledge in policy were awarded independently, The Australian reports. Space funding sits alongside AUKUS Pillar 2 workstreams in the government's

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

The Australian says Chalmers is running out of budget backflips

Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** is running out of retreats to perform on what The Australian calls a big-taxing, broken-promise budget. The masthead separately reports a *\$160 million* loss from a further tax backdown that leaves eligible start-ups unclear on who gets the capital gains tax carve-out.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Latest tax retreat leaves start-ups unclear on CGT carve-out

Jim Chalmers' latest tax backdown leaves eligible start-ups in the dark over who qualifies for the capital gains tax carve-out, at a cost The Australian puts at *\$160 million*.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Inquirer argues Australia's economic decline is self-inflicted

The Australian's Inquirer section argues Australia's economic decline is entirely self-inflicted, invoking what it calls 'Argentinisation'. The ASX 200 closed at 8,741, down 2.94 percent, on September 11.

PACIFIC-POLITICS · FIJI SUN

Fiji tightens scholarship rules as tertiary support budget hits \$160 million

Fiji will cut allowances for students placed on a second academic probation from 2027, Education Minister **Aseri Radrodro** said, with suspended students receiving neither tuition nor allowances. The government is supporting 23,137 new and continuing students with a \$160 million allocation.

• UPCOMING

SEP
2026

U.S. House of Representatives vote on tariffs on buyers of Russian oil and gas

Australian and New Zealand energy importers price off the same crude and product markets the tariffs would disrupt.

SEP
2026

Nepal to raise flood reconstruction costs at the UN General Assembly

Pacific states pursuing loss-and-damage finance will watch how a climate-vulnerable state frames shared responsibility at the General Assembly.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Peters' unapproved Forum hosting commitment becomes a live campaign issue before voters start casting ballots.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set Wellington's Pacific and defence policy.

• THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ABC NEWS

[Research names Australia among the safest places in a global catastrophe](#)

New research in the journal *Global Challenges* finds Australia's isolation, self-sufficiency and political stability let it withstand most global catastrophic risks, defined as events threatening *10 percent* of human lives. Co-author **Matt Boyd** said several such scenarios 'are guaranteed to happen'.

US-AUSTRALIA

THE AUSTRALIAN

[Anthropic says Iran used its American AI model to target US Navy warships](#)

Anthropic said Iran used its American-built AI model to target United States Navy warships, in a Wall Street Journal report carried by The Australian. The case bears on export-control and technology-transfer debates running through AUKUS Pillar 2.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FBC NEWS (FIJI)

[Fiji Ports Terminal chair appointed Permanent Secretary for Public Enterprises](#)

Public Service Commission chair **Luke Rokovada** confirmed **Pita Wise**, chair of Fiji Ports Terminal, as Permanent Secretary for Public Enterprises, effective Tuesday, following endorsement by Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka.

FIJI SUN

[Fiji's Land Transport Authority chief executive resigns](#)

Land Transport Authority chief executive **Irimaia Rokosawa** resigned effective September 11, with general manager policy and business development **Makitalena Drova** appointed acting chief executive. Deputy board chairperson **Miliana Vulakouvaki** said the board accepted the resignation, which was for personal reasons.

FBC NEWS (FIJI)

[Fiji health ministry flags rising respiratory illness activity](#)

Fiji's Ministry of Health and Medical Services urged vigilance after the latest Flu Tracking Fiji Weekly Interim Report showed rising respiratory illness for the week of August 31 to September 6. Assistant Health Minister **Penioni Ravunawa** cited *177 participants* in the reporting period.

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

[Nepal puts flood reconstruction bill at \\$6.67 billion and calls it shared responsibility](#)

Nepal's foreign ministry says reconstruction after the August 26 floods will cost *\$US4.78 billion*, or \$6.67 billion, with \$US57.67 million needed within six months. Spokesman **Lok Bahadur Chhetri** said a post-disaster needs assessment is under way, and Prime Minister **Balendra Shah** is expected to raise the issue at the UN General Assembly.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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